Crown-of-thorns starfish

Crown-of-thorns starfish are large starfish that eat **coral polyps**. In some years large outbreaks of the starfish occur on Australia's greatest tourist attraction, the Great Barrier Reef. The females produce approximately 60 million eggs a year. The eggs drift for months in the water as **zooplankton**, feeding on microscopic **algae**. In an outbreak year more of the eggs reach maturity because more nutrients have washed into the sea, creating more algae for the zooplankton to eat.

Once they grow larger they settle on coral. Adult starfish can reach 30 cm in diameter. They are covered in sharp poisonous spines that can pierce clothing. A single starfish can move up to 20 m per hour, searching for food, and in a year they can eat around 6 m^2 of living coral reef. As adults they have few predators.

☞ **1** What factors make the crown-of-thorns starfish such an effective predator?

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2 Why do you think biologists want to control starfish outbreaks on the Great Barrier Reef?

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3 As more humans farm coastal areas, more **nutrients** make their way into the sea, boosting algae populations. How does this contribute to increased crown-of-thorns starfish numbers?

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4 Match the phrases below.

Destroyed coral populations	by injections of Sodium bisulphate.
Adult starfish are controlled	few natural predators.
Crown-of-thorns starfish	take ten years to recover.
This starfish has very	have up to 21 arms.

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